

Later Wittgenstein — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Eight verified PYQs and nine original solved models

This is the solved Mains/PYQ workbook. All model answers are independent learner-practice answers, never official UPSC answer keys.

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Source, coverage and ownership

- Exact wording and marks: [2018–2025 verified ledger](#) and [2026 verified ledger](#).
- Direct ownership: 2018 Q1(c), 2019 Q3(b), 2020 Q4(c), 2022 Q1(c), 2023 Q4(c), 2024 Q1(d), 2025 Q3(a), 2026 Q3(c).
- 2021 has no directly owned part. Early picture theory and positivist verification are bounded comparisons owned by Topics 06 and 07.

Bounded route obligations

- WP-2018-Q3C-SAYING-SHOWING: **Topic 06 owns** saying/showing, logical form and the *Tractatus* answer. Topic 08 contributes only the later **plurality of methods** contrast.
- WP-2021-Q4C-WHEREOF-SILENCE: **Topic 06 owns** the silence proposition, ladder and limits of the sayable. Topic 08 contributes only the later **grammar and therapy** contrast.
- WP-2022-Q3C-PICTORIAL-LOGICAL-FORM: **Topic 06 owns** pictorial form, logical form and representation. Topic 08 contributes only the later shift from formal determinacy to determinacy in **practice**.

Demand map and recurring themes

Demand	High-value answer spine
Early-to-later transition	picture and logical form → internal pressure → diverse uses → games and therapy → qualified continuity
Meaning and mental ideas	Augustinian model → counterexamples → mastery of technique → rules and criteria → non-behaviourist verdict
Family resemblance	games case → overlapping similarities → language plurality → practice-bounded openness
Forms of life	PI 19 → agreement in practice → lion → bedrock → relativism qualification
Private language	exact target → rule and correctness → diary S → beetle → criteria and avowals → objection and reply

Introductions, keywords and diagrams

- **Definition opening:** define the exact target before evaluating it.
- **Contrast opening:** state the early view and the later correction in one sentence.
- **Problem opening:** identify the correctness or normativity problem that drives the argument.
- **Keywords:** use; language-game; family resemblance; form of life; mastery of a technique; rule-following; correct versus seems-correct; private ostension; criterion; symptom; avowal; perspicuous representation; therapy.

NAME-OBJECT MODEL -> diverse linguistic jobs -> meaning in use
USE -> LANGUAGE-GAME -> FORM OF LIFE -> RULE AND CORRECTION
PRIVATE OSTENSION -> no independent standard -> no rule -> no private language

Time and word discipline

Marks	Locked practice band	Guidance
10	150–200 words	2 minutes planning; 7–8 minutes writing
15	250–300 words	3 minutes planning; 13–15 minutes writing
20	340–400 words	4 minutes planning; 18–21 minutes writing

Verified directly owned PYQs

1. 2018 Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: How does the notion of 'family resemblance' help Wittgenstein to uphold that 'Language is a game'? Discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

Family resemblance explains how Wittgenstein can compare language with games without claiming that every linguistic activity shares one essence. When we inspect board-games, ball-games, card-games and solitary games, no single feature such as competition, amusement or skill occurs in all. Instead, there is a network of overlapping and criss-crossing similarities, like resemblances among family members.

Language displays the same pattern. Reporting, ordering, praying, joking, calculating and avowing are language-games woven into different activities. Their unity is not one referential or pictorial function. The expression "language is a game" therefore redirects inquiry from an abstract essence to trained moves, circumstances and standards within practices. "Don't think, but look" names this descriptive method.

The claim does not make classification arbitrary. Central cases, examples, correction and shared practice guide applications even where boundaries remain open. Family resemblance thus supports language-games by replacing necessary and sufficient conditions with a disciplined but non-essentialist account of conceptual unity.

Measured model-answer words: 152

Explicit qualification / criticism: A critic may argue that resemblance is unlimited, since any two things resemble in some respect. The reply is that established practice, not bare similarity, determines which resemblances matter.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 10-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

2. 2019 Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Later Wittgenstein does not defeat solipsism by proving an external world. He asks whether the solipsist can give sense to the claim that only private experience is real. To formulate that privileged inner world, the solipsist requires words whose meanings are fixed by experiences accessible in principle only to the individual.

Rule-following supplies the first pressure. A meaningful sign must distinguish correct application from merely seeming correct. An interpretation cannot provide the final standard because it invites another interpretation. Standards are displayed in a trained practice of correction and continuation.

The diary case at section 258 sharpens the point. A diarist associates "S" with a private sensation and later records its recurrence. Yet the present impression is both application and alleged test. If whatever seems right is right, there is no usable contrast between right and wrong. Memory cannot validate itself within

the same private ceremony.

The beetle analogy at section 293 reinforces, but does not duplicate, the argument. If everyone calls an inaccessible box-content “beetle,” the hidden object has no role in the shared grammar and may vary or be absent. Public use carries meaning.

Thus a world grounded solely in private objects cannot be stated in the language it requires. The culmination is grammatical: private semantic foundations collapse, not inner experience. Solitude remains possible where a person uses stable, learnable public-type criteria.

The answer should therefore distinguish the doctrine's central target from stronger conclusions that its argument does not establish.

This qualification preserves the explanatory gain while preventing an examination answer from turning a grammatical diagnosis into an unsupported metaphysical claim.

Measured model-answer words: 263

Explicit qualification / criticism: The argument may not prove that actual community agreement is necessary. Its strongest conclusion is narrower: present private seeming cannot by itself institute a norm of correctness.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 15-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

3. 2020 Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: “But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences—his feelings, moods and the rest—for his private use?” Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Wittgenstein's answer is that an essentially private language cannot be established. "Private" here does not mean a secret code, solitary speech or an unshared natural language. It means signs whose meanings are fixed by sensations that only one speaker could in principle identify.

The core argument concerns correctness. In the diary example, the speaker associates "S" with a sensation and records later recurrences. A rule for "S" requires a distinction between applying it correctly and merely believing it has been applied correctly. But private ostension supplies no independent standard of sameness. If present seeming is the only court of appeal, "whatever seems right is right," which means that talk of right has lost its function.

The beetle-in-a-box analogy shows that an inaccessible private object cannot determine a public word's grammar. Its content may differ or be absent while the word continues to work. Sensation language is instead connected with outward, defeasible criteria and learned expressive practices. First-person "I am in pain" normally functions as an avowal, not an inference from observed behaviour.

The strongest objection is behaviourism: does public criteria reduce pain to pain-behaviour? Wittgenstein's reply is that criteria are defeasible. Pretence and suppression allow pain and behaviour to diverge. He denies the private object's foundational semantic role, not sensations.

The argument convincingly blocks private ostension as a complete foundation. It is less decisive if expanded into the stronger thesis that an actual community must inspect every rule application.

The answer should therefore distinguish the doctrine's central target from stronger conclusions that its argument does not establish.

Measured model-answer words: 257

Explicit qualification / criticism: A solitary speaker using an inherited or repeatable technique remains possible; logical privacy, not physical isolation, is the target.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 15-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

4. 2022 Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's notion of language as form of life.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger

Element	Requirement
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

The official wording prints “motion,” evidently for “notion.” The intended claim is defensible: language is intelligible only within a form of life, a background of activity, natural reaction, training and shared judgment.

Section 19 states that to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life. The builders' calls work because ordering, fetching and constructing form one practice. Agreement is therefore not primarily agreement in opinions; it is practical agreement that makes particular disputes, corrections and innovations possible. The speaking-lion remark adds that shared vocabulary alone may fail where activities and reactions are radically different. At justificatory bedrock, explanation ends in “This is simply what I do.”

This view explains why meaning cannot be grounded in an isolated idea or a self-interpreting rule. It also avoids pure conventionalism because bodily reactions and natural history constrain practices.

Its limitation is under-definition: “form of life” can be read biologically, culturally or as both. If made wholly cultural it risks relativism; if made wholly natural it neglects historical change. Properly qualified, it is a tenable account of the enabling background of language, not a complete social theory.

Measured model-answer words: 185

Explicit qualification / criticism: Tenability requires resisting both extremes: forms of life are neither majority opinions nor an exhaustive biological explanation.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 10-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

5. 2023 Q4(c) • 15 marks

Question: What were the main reasons that led Wittgenstein to shift from picture-theory of meaning to use-theory of meaning? Critically discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

The shift arose from internal difficulties in the *Tractatus* and a broader change in philosophical method. The early view explained factual propositions as pictures of possible facts sharing logical form. Analysis was expected to reach simple names and logically independent elementary propositions.

First, colour exclusion created internal pressure. “This patch is red all over” excludes “this patch is green all over,” although apparently elementary propositions were meant to be independent. Second, the Augustinian naming model was too narrow. It fits some concrete nouns but not “if,” “five,” questions, commands, jokes or avowals. Third, ostension proved unable to fix its own dimension of application; pointing to two red squares does not say whether colour, shape, number or material is taught.

The later positive turn is qualified. Section 43 says that for a large class of cases, though not all, a word's meaning is its use in language. Words operate like diverse tools; understanding is mastery of a technique. Language-games are woven into activities and sustained by forms of life, training and correction. Philosophy consequently describes grammar and offers perspicuous reminders rather than constructing one ideal calculus.

The shift gains fidelity to linguistic diversity and explains norm-sensitive practices beyond factual representation. Its cost is reduced theoretical unity. “Use” may seem circular unless rule-following and criteria explain correctness, and therapeutic description invites the charge of quietism.

The best verdict is not that picture and use are rival exhaustive theories. Later Wittgenstein rejects the demand for one essence while preserving the aim of philosophical clarification.

Measured model-answer words: 251

Explicit qualification / criticism: Colour exclusion is an important pressure rather than a single conclusive cause; the semantic and methodological criticisms complete the explanation.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 15-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

6. 2024 Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak — a language that is essentially private? Discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

An essentially private language would contain signs for sensations accessible in principle only to one speaker. It is not a secret code, private diary in an ordinary language or solitary use of an inherited technique.

Wittgenstein argues that a meaningful sign needs a rule distinguishing correct from incorrect application. In the diary case, a speaker associates “S” with a private sensation and later marks its recurrence. No standard independent of present seeming establishes that the same sensation has returned. If whatever seems right is right, the distinction between being right and thinking oneself right disappears; therefore no rule has been constituted.

The beetle-in-a-box analogy supports this result. Where the public use of “beetle” proceeds without access to anyone’s box, the hidden item cannot determine the word’s grammar and may even be absent. Sensation words instead acquire sense within practices of expression, response and defeasible outward criteria.

The conclusion does not deny sensations or require another person to monitor every utterance. A solitary person can use public-type techniques. What is impossible is a language whose correctness is grounded solely in logically private ostension.

Measured model-answer words: 182

Explicit qualification / criticism: The argument establishes a semantic limit on private grounding, not an empirical claim that isolated people cannot speak.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 10-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

7. 2025 Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used." Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	340–400 words

Timed independent model answer

The printed statement contains an unmatched quotation mark before "logical structure," but its contrast is clear. It places the early search for one logical architecture of factual sense against the later examination of actual linguistic practices.

In the *Tractatus*, a proposition is meaningful by picturing a possible fact. Proposition and fact share logical form; analysis was expected to terminate in simple names and independent elementary propositions. Philosophy clarified the limits of what could be said. This was not merely a proposal to replace bad everyday sentences, since the *Tractatus* also regarded ordinary propositions as logically ordered. The decisive commitment was to one general form and a depth analysis beneath their surface.

Several pressures produced the transition. Colour exclusion challenged elementary independence. The Augustinian picture in which every word names an object could not explain numerals, logical particles, questions, orders, jokes or sensation avowals. Ostensive definition also required prior training to select colour, shape, number or another dimension. Wittgenstein increasingly treated the craving for crystalline logical purity as a philosophical imposition.

The *Investigations* therefore asks how expressions are actually used. Section 43 cautiously connects meaning with use for a large class of cases. Words are tools with diverse functions; understanding is mastery of a technique. Language-games combine signs with activities, while family resemblance replaces one common essence. Training, forms of life and public-type criteria explain rule-following.

The methodological consequence is therapy. Philosophy compares cases, gives reminders and constructs perspicuous representations so that language removed from its ordinary work returns home. It dissolves rather than theoretically solves many inherited puzzles.

The later view handles linguistic diversity and private-language problems more convincingly, but it sacrifices systematic explanation and faces questions about normativity and quietism. The transition is thus from one general logical account of factual sense to plural, practice-grounded grammatical

investigation, not from logic to arbitrary usage.

The answer should therefore distinguish the doctrine's central target from stronger conclusions that its argument does not establish.

This qualification preserves the explanatory gain while preventing an examination answer from turning a grammatical diagnosis into an unsupported metaphysical claim.

Measured model-answer words: 343

Explicit qualification / criticism: The strongest balanced answer preserves continuity in clarification while recognizing discontinuity about logical essence, semantic foundation and philosophical method.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 20-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

8. 2026 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Can words be viewed as the ideas in the mind of the person who uses them? Answer with reference to the philosophy of later Wittgenstein.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled PYQ ledger
Demand decoding	Answer the directive and its internal relation, not a generic note on Later Wittgenstein
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Later Wittgenstein would reject the general equation of words with ideas in a speaker's mind. An image, feeling or intention may accompany speech, but such an episode neither constitutes the word's meaning nor supplies its standard of correct use.

The Augustinian picture encourages mentalism by treating words as names and ideas as their private objects. Yet expressions such as “if,” “not,” “five,” requests and avowals have no uniform inner item that they name. Even with concrete words, different speakers may associate different images while using the expression identically, and one speaker may retain the same competence while imagery changes.

Section 43 redirects inquiry to use within language. Understanding is mastery of a technique: the ability to continue, respond and accept correction in relevant cases. Rule-following deepens the point. A private interpretation cannot fix all future applications because any interpretation can itself be interpreted differently. Normativity is exhibited in practice.

The diary argument then blocks private ideas as semantic foundations. If “S” is tied only to an inward sensation, no independent criterion distinguishes correct recurrence from present seeming. The beetle analogy similarly shows that an inaccessible object drops out of the public grammar. First-person avowals preserve inner life without making it an inner-object report.

This is not behaviourism. Outward criteria are defeasible, and Wittgenstein does not deny images or sensations. He denies that their private occurrence explains meaning. Words are best viewed as instruments in language-games, while ideas are possible accompaniments whose identity and relevance are themselves described through public grammar.

Measured model-answer words: 250

Explicit qualification / criticism: Mental episodes can causally prompt expression and enrich thought; the denial concerns their alleged role as self-authenticating semantic standards.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the named doctrine, uses exact technical distinctions, answers the directive, includes a criticism or qualification and reaches a defended judgement.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 15-mark band and reserve the final minute for checking the directive, terminology and conclusion.

Original solved practice

The first three models are retained package originals. Originals 4-9 restore the six distinct exercises in the authoritative formal workbook. Each restored exercise has its own timed answer; additional distinctions from the longer formal model are preserved under **Depth refinement** and are not counted in the timed word total.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why ostensive definition cannot by itself fix meaning, and relate this failure to meaning as use.

Demand decoding

Build a direct thesis, reconstruct the mechanism, test the strongest objection and close with a qualified judgement.

Timed model answer

Pointing is not a self-interpreting semantic ceremony. If a teacher indicates two red squares and says "red," the learner may attend to colour, shape, number, material, location or the teacher's gesture. The sample does not select which dimension should govern future applications.

Ostensive definition succeeds only within prior training. Contrasting samples, correction and repeated use teach the learner how to continue. A colour chart then functions as a standard inside a method of representation rather than as an object carrying its own interpretation.

This supports the qualified claim in section 43 that, for a large class of cases, meaning is use in language. Use is not frequency or personal convenience; it is a norm-governed role in a language-game. Reference remains one legitimate role, but it cannot explain the conditions under which pointing counts as teaching reference.

The residual question is whether appeal to practice is circular. Wittgenstein treats trained practice as bedrock rather than offering another hidden mechanism. The account explains how ostension works while refusing the demand for a final self-interpreting sign.

Measured model-answer words: 173

Explicit qualification / criticism: The account does not deny ostensive teaching; it denies that pointing operates without grammar, attention and training.

Why this earns marks: It answers the original demand independently, names the decisive concepts, develops the argument and gives a proportionate critical verdict.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 10-mark band and use the final minute to verify the conclusion follows from the body.

Original 2 · 15 marks

Question: How do language-games and forms of life support rule-following without reducing correctness to social conformity?

Demand decoding

Build a direct thesis, reconstruct the mechanism, test the strongest objection and close with a qualified judgement.

Timed model answer

A language-game is language interwoven with activity, including participants, purposes, training and standards. In the builders' example, "Slab!" works because an order, a trained response and a building task form one practice. A form of life is the wider background of action and natural reaction that makes such moves intelligible.

These notions answer the rule-following problem. No interpretation can determine every future application of a rule, because the interpretation requires application and generates regress. Grasp of a rule is instead exhibited in obeying, correcting and going against it in actual cases. Finite instruction succeeds because learners share techniques and judgments that extend beyond the examples.

Correctness is not thereby whatever a majority happens to do. A majority may misunderstand a calculation, and an innovator may be right. The relevant agreement is not a vote on each proposition but the deeper practice that gives "calculation," "correction" and "mistake" their roles. Natural constraints, purposes and internal relations among moves limit acceptable continuation.

The view nevertheless faces pressure. If every standard is internal to practice, radical criticism and conceptual change may appear difficult to explain. Wittgenstein can answer that practices contain contestation and evolve through uptake, but he supplies no complete theory of legitimate reform.

Thus language-games and forms of life ground normativity in shared, teachable practices without reducing truth or correctness to numerical conformity.

The answer should therefore distinguish the doctrine's central target from stronger conclusions that its argument does not establish.

This qualification preserves the explanatory gain while preventing an examination answer from turning a grammatical diagnosis into an unsupported metaphysical claim.

Measured model-answer words: 261

Explicit qualification / criticism: Community is neither a constantly present audience nor an infallible majority; it names the public-type space of standards.

Why this earns marks: It answers the original demand independently, names the decisive concepts, develops the argument and gives a proportionate critical verdict.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 15-mark band and use the final minute to verify the conclusion follows from the body.

Original 3 · 20 marks

Question: Does the critique of private language complete Wittgenstein's transition from picture theory to the later conception of language? Critically examine.

Demand decoding

Build a direct thesis, reconstruct the mechanism, test the strongest objection and close with a qualified judgement.

Timed model answer

The critique of private language is not an isolated argument about diaries. It is the culminating test of the later claim that meaning is sustained by use, rule-following and criteria rather than by a word's relation to a self-authenticating object.

The Tractatus centred factual sense on picturing: names correlate with objects and propositions share logical form with possible facts. The Investigations attacks the temptation to generalize this name-object model. Words perform many jobs, ostension requires training, concepts exhibit family resemblance and language-games are woven into forms of life.

Rule-following supplies the normative bridge. No interpretation fixes all future applications, since another interpretation would be needed. A rule is grasped in trained practices of obeying, correcting and continuing. The proposed private diary then fails. A sign "S" tied solely to an inward sensation provides no standard independent of present seeming. Where seeming right is being right, the correct-incorrect distinction disappears. The beetle analogy adds that an inaccessible object does no work in the public grammar of a sensation word.

In this sense the argument completes the transition. It demonstrates, at the hardest case, why neither an external simple object nor an internal idea can carry meaning independently of use. Sensation language rests on expression, outward criteria and first-person avowal, not inner naming.

However, "completion" should not mean a deductive system. The argument depends on a contested account of normativity, and critics ask whether a solitary individual can preserve standards through memory and stable practice. The behaviourism charge also arises, though defeasible criteria allow pain and pain-behaviour to diverge.

The private-language critique therefore completes the transition architecturally: it unites use, games, rules and therapy against private foundations. It does not end debate about community, inner experience or conceptual innovation.

The answer should therefore distinguish the doctrine's central target from stronger conclusions that its argument does not establish.

This qualification preserves the explanatory gain while preventing an examination answer from turning a grammatical diagnosis into an unsupported metaphysical claim.

A balanced judgement should rank the internal argument first, the objection second and the limited conclusion last.

Measured model-answer words: 343

Explicit qualification / criticism: The conclusion is strongest when limited to logically private ostension; it need not deny solitary competence, sensations or first-person authority.

Why this earns marks: It answers the original demand independently, names the decisive concepts, develops the argument and gives a proportionate critical verdict.

Word and time guidance

Write within the locked 20-mark band and use the final minute to verify the conclusion follows from the body.

Original 4 · 10 marks

Question: "An ostensive definition can be variously interpreted in every case." Examine the significance of this remark for Wittgenstein's account of meaning.

Demand decoding

Explain why pointing is underdeterminate, identify the practice that makes it work, and connect the result to meaning as use and private ostension.

Timed model answer

The remark denies that pointing can connect a word with its meaning independently of an already understood practice. If a teacher points to two nuts and says "two", the learner may take the word to name the number, colour, shape, material or even the displayed group. Adding "this number is called two" merely presupposes mastery of the word "number".

Ostensive definition therefore works only when the learner's attention and expected response have been trained. Wittgenstein's chess example makes the point: showing someone the king teaches its meaning only if the place of that piece is already prepared within the game. The sample functions as a standard inside a method of representation; it does not interpret itself.

This supports the qualified doctrine of meaning as use. Naming is one language-game among others, and its success depends on grammar, correction and technique. The same argument also anticipates the private-language critique: inward pointing cannot create a standard when no practice distinguishes remembering correctly from merely seeming correct.

Depth refinement. PI §§28-31 connect the ambiguity of ostension, the regress in explanations, and the prepared place. PI §§5-6 add training, while PI §258 shows why private ostension cannot supply the public-type norm that ordinary ostension presupposes.

Measured model-answer words: 164

Explicit qualification / criticism: Wittgenstein does not deny ostensive teaching; he denies that it can fix meaning without a grammar of attention, continuation and correction.

Why this earns marks

It reconstructs the ambiguity, supplies the chess case, and connects the negative result to the positive use-theory and the private-language argument.

Original 5 · 10 marks

Question: Explain the distinction between a criterion and a symptom, and show why Wittgenstein needs it.

Demand decoding

Define both roles, apply them to sensation language, and show how the distinction blocks the behaviourism objection.

Timed model answer

A criterion is a grammatical ground for applying a concept; a symptom is an empirical sign whose correlation with a condition is discovered inductively. In the *Blue Book* example, if angina is defined through a particular bacillus, the bacillus is criterial, whereas an inflamed throat may remain only symptomatic.

Wittgenstein needs the distinction when explaining sensation language. Pain-behaviour in suitable circumstances is part of the learned grammar of "pain": it licenses third-person attribution and gives the concept outward application. Yet a groan, pulse or withdrawal may mislead, because criteria can be defeated by pretence, injury context or contrary evidence. Pain is therefore not identical with behaviour.

The distinction preserves two claims together. An inner process cannot serve as a self-authenticating private standard, since the concept requires outward criteria; but genuine sensations and first-person avowals remain. PI §354 also warns that the roles of criterion and symptom can fluctuate with the language-game. The argument is grammatical, not a reduction of mind to observable movement.

Depth refinement. PI §580 states that an inner process stands in need of outward criteria; PI §§304 and 307 resist ontological elimination, and PI §244 treats first-person present-tense sensation utterances as avowals rather than reports based on observation.

Measured model-answer words: 163

Explicit qualification / criticism: Criteria are defeasible grounds within a practice, not infallible behavioural entailments.

Why this earns marks

It defines the distinction, uses the canonical example, explains its role in sensation grammar, and directly answers the behaviourism objection.

Original 6 · 15 marks

Question: "No course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule." Critically examine Wittgenstein's treatment of this paradox.

Demand decoding

Reconstruct the regress, explain why the paradox is a reductio rather than Wittgenstein's final scepticism, and assess the practice-based response.

Timed model answer

Wittgenstein's paradox targets the picture that a rule determines its applications through an interpretation attached to the sign. The "+2" pupil of PI §185 continues 1000, 1004, 1008 and claims to be proceeding in the same way. More examples or verbal explanations cannot finally settle the dispute, because each expression can itself be interpreted differently.

PI §201 therefore states the paradox: any course of action can be made to accord with a rule, and so can also be made to conflict with it. This is not the conclusion that rules determine nothing. It is a reductio of interpretation as the universal bridge between a sign and its application. Substituting one expression for another merely postpones the question of how that expression is used.

The resolution is a way of grasping a rule that is not an interpretation but is exhibited in what we call obeying and going against it in actual cases. PI §202 adds that obeying a rule is a practice. Training, correction and shared techniques make continuation norm-governed rather than mechanically forced by an abstract formula.

Two cautions are essential. Practice is not mere behavioural regularity, because mistakes remain possible; nor is correctness whatever a majority votes for. Kripke's sceptical reading usefully exposes the failure of meanings, intentions and dispositions to determine every case, but his community-based solution risks becoming a theory that Wittgenstein's therapeutic method rejects.

The paradox is thus compelling against interpretationism. Its positive result is modest: normativity is displayed in stable, teachable practices, not derived from a further occult fact.

Depth refinement. The key textual sequence is PI §185, §201 and §202. Baker, Hacker and McDowell read it as dissolution; Kripke presents a sceptical paradox and solution. PI §§128 and 133 support caution about turning the response into a constructive social theory.

Measured model-answer words: 255

Explicit qualification / criticism: Shared practice explains the space of correct and incorrect continuation, but Wittgenstein gives no complete theory of legitimate conceptual innovation.

Why this earns marks

It separates paradox, diagnosis and resolution, then evaluates both sceptical and therapeutic readings without reducing correctness to conformity.

Original 7 · 15 marks

Question: "Philosophy leaves everything as it is." Does this commit Wittgenstein to quietism? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Locate PI §124 in its grammatical context, identify the real restriction on philosophy, and test both the social-conservatism and disciplinary-quietism charges.

Timed model answer

PI §124 says that philosophy may not interfere with the actual use of language, can only describe it, and leaves everything as it is. The immediate object of non-interference is grammar, not laws, institutions or political arrangements. The remark therefore does not by itself entail social conservatism.

The restriction follows from Wittgenstein's diagnosis of philosophical trouble. Language goes on holiday, a picture holds us captive, and we lose our way in the grammar we already command. If the problem is conceptual disorientation rather than missing empirical information, a new theory or foundation supplies the wrong kind of remedy. Philosophy instead assembles reminders, constructs intermediate cases and offers a perspicuous representation that lets us see connections. The fly-bottle image describes dissolution, not passivity.

Nevertheless, a genuine quietist residue remains. PI §§109, 126 and 128 reject explanation, deduction and debatable philosophical theses; PI §133 measures success by being able to stop philosophising. This excludes much explanatory, revisionary and foundational work traditionally claimed by philosophy.

The positive method also matters to the verdict. Perspicuous representation can expose unnoticed relations among uses, and invented intermediate cases can loosen a misleading picture. Those are intellectually productive operations even when they yield no explanatory theory. A critic may still ask whether grammatical description can remain neutral when choosing which uses are normal or which comparisons are illuminating.

The best verdict is therefore divided. The charge of political acquiescence overreads a remark about language, while the charge of disciplinary narrowing is substantially correct. The method is active as therapy but quietist about constructing philosophical theory.

Depth refinement. PI §38, §115 and §123 supply the diagnosis; PI §§122 and 127 supply the positive operations. The self-application objection remains: the general claim that philosophy should not advance general theses can itself look like one.

Measured model-answer words: 258

Explicit qualification / criticism: Plural "methods, like different therapies" softens, but does not remove, the restriction on philosophical theorising.

Why this earns marks

It distinguishes political from methodological quietism, shows what therapy positively does, and concedes the strongest remaining objection.

Original 8 · 20 marks

Question: Does the account of language-games and forms of life commit Wittgenstein to relativism? Critically examine, with reference to the notion of agreement in judgments.

Demand decoding

State the relativist pressure, analyse PI §§241-242, distinguish conditions of intelligibility from truth-makers, and identify the genuine residual problem.

Timed model answer

Language-games and forms of life appear to invite relativism because standards of meaningful use are internal to historically variable practices. PI §23 says that speaking is part of an activity, while PI §217 ends justification with "This is simply what I do." If practice supplies the terminus, it may seem that each community makes its own truth.

PI §241 directly rejects that inference. Human agreement does not decide what is true or false; rather, human beings make true and false statements within the language in which they agree. The agreement is not convergence of opinions about every proposition but agreement in form of life. It establishes a common space in which assertion, evidence, correction and disagreement have determinate roles.

PI §242 deepens the point through judgment. If measuring results varied wildly from person to person, there would not be many inaccurate measurements but no established practice of measuring. Shared judgments are therefore conditions for having a subject matter, not votes that determine each result. Disagreement and error remain possible only against that background.

Three considerations further resist simple relativism. Forms of life include natural reactions and human natural history, not convention alone. A practice contains standards of mistake, so group regularity cannot automatically equal correctness. Finally, Wittgenstein can describe unfamiliar and changing games, which presupposes comparison rather than sealed conceptual worlds.

Moreover, innovation is intelligible only because a new move can be taught, challenged and integrated into consequences already shared. Conceptual change therefore modifies a practice rather than escaping every standard at once.

Yet the account leaves a real difficulty. It explains how standards operate within a practice more clearly than how rival practices should rationally criticise one another. Appeals to bedrock may terminate justification without explaining reform, oppression or epistemic progress. The sparse textual role of "form of life" also counsels against building a complete cultural theory from it.

Wittgenstein is thus not committed to truth-by-consensus relativism. His position is better read as transcendental and grammatical: shared practices make truth-evaluable judgment possible. The unresolved residue is not that every practice is right, but that no systematic account of cross-practice adjudication is supplied.

Depth refinement. PI §§19 and 23 connect language with activity; §§241-242 separate agreement in language from agreement in opinion; §§25 and 415 locate the background partly in natural history. The lion remark marks a difficulty of intelligibility, not a proof that understanding another form of life is

impossible.

Measured model-answer words: 353

Explicit qualification / criticism: The anti-relativist reading preserves mistake and disagreement, while conceding Wittgenstein's silence about rational comparison across practices.

Why this earns marks

It reconstructs the strongest relativist inference, answers it textually, and preserves the adjudication problem as a serious but narrower criticism.

Original 9 · 20 marks

Question: What exactly does the private-language argument establish, and what does it leave standing? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Define the exact PI §243 target, reconstruct the diary and beetle arguments, distinguish the conclusion from behaviourism, and state what survives.

Timed model answer

The private-language argument attacks a language whose words refer to what only the speaker can know and which another person cannot understand even in principle. Its target is logical privacy as a foundation for meaning, not sensations, solitude or first-person authority.

PI §258 tests a private ostensive definition. The diarist marks recurring sensation *S* and resolves to use the sign for the same experience. Yet the proposed check is only that the present use seems right according to the same private memory. Where seeming right is being right, there is no operational distinction between correct and incorrect application, and therefore no rule has been established. PI §265 compares the procedure to checking one copy of a newspaper against another copy of the same paper. PI §270 shows the contrast: once a manometer and public circumstances provide criteria, the sign functions, while the private identification becomes idle.

The beetle-in-the-box at PI §293 adds that an inaccessible item which may vary, disappear or be absent cannot determine the grammar of a shared sensation-word. The item is not denied; it drops out of the explanation of linguistic meaning.

Several things remain standing. Sensations remain real: PI §304 says they are "not a something, but not a nothing either." A solitary person may retain a language because the relevant standards can be public-type, stable and in principle teachable. First-person sensation utterances also keep their asymmetry: PI §244 treats "I am in pain" primarily as an avowal, not an observational report. PI §580 requires outward criteria for the concept of an inner process without identifying the process with behaviour.

Critics press memory and community objections. Public checks also depend on memory, and it is disputed whether actual communal correction is necessary. Wittgenstein's strongest reply is grammatical: public practice supplies multiple independent roles, consequences and corrections, whereas the wholly private

diary stipulates all of them through one seeming.

The argument therefore succeeds against private ostension as a semantic foundation. It does not prove behaviourism, deny phenomenal character, or show that an isolated human being cannot follow rules.

Depth refinement. PI §202 supplies the practice requirement; §§243, 258, 265, 270 and 293 form the core sequence. PI §§246, 304, 307-308 and 354 preserve first-person asymmetry and defeasible criteria while blocking both Cartesian foundationalism and reductive behaviourism.

Measured model-answer words: 341

Explicit qualification / criticism: The conclusion is decisive only against essentially private standards; actual community membership remains an interpretive question.

Why this earns marks

It states the exact target, reconstructs the complete argument, separates what is rejected from what survives, and addresses the strongest objections.

Self-evaluation and endurance ladder

1. Reconstruct the relevant diagram orally.
2. Write a thesis and conclusion without notes.
3. Produce a five-minute answer spine.
4. Complete one pain-free 10-mark answer.
5. Progress to a 15-mark answer, then a 20-mark answer.
6. Stop if pain, numbness, tingling, swelling or weakness increases.

Final examiner checklist

- Exact private-language target defined.
- PI 43 qualification preserved.
- Rule-following is not reduced to majority vote.
- Inner life is not denied.
- Every comparison is labelled and ownership is not duplicated.
- Printed anomalies in 2022 and 2025 are preserved when quoting the question.
- Final verdict is graded, not absolute.